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Wednesday 7:58 PM

Observer - observed relationship 12 mark

Observer–Observed Relationship (12 Marks)

Definition

The **observer–observed relationship** is the interaction between the **researcher (observer)** and the **participant or phenomenon being studied (observed)** during data collection. The nature of this relationship affects the objectivity, validity, and reliability of the research findings.

Types of Observer–Observed Relationship

1. **Complete Participant**
   - The observer becomes a member of the group.
   - Participants do not know they are being observed.
   - Example: A researcher joins a community group without revealing the research purpose.
2. **Participant as Observer**
   - The researcher participates in the activities.
   - Participants know that research is being conducted.
   - Encourages trust and openness.
3. **Observer as Participant**
   - The researcher mainly observes with limited interaction.
   - Participants are aware of the observation.
   - Common in interviews and short-term field studies.
4. **Complete Observer**
   - The researcher does not participate.
   - Observes from a distance without interacting.
   - Suitable for structured observation.

Importance

- Helps collect accurate and reliable data.

- Reduces observer bias.
- Improves objectivity.
- Builds rapport with participants when appropriate.
- Ensures ethical conduct during research.

Advantages

- Provides first-hand information.
- Helps understand real-life behaviour.
- Improves the quality of data.
- Useful for qualitative research.

Disadvantages

- Observer bias may occur.
- Participants may change their behaviour (Hawthorne effect).
- Time-consuming and costly.
- Ethical issues may arise, especially if participants are unaware of observation.

Precautions

- Maintain neutrality and objectivity.
- Obtain informed consent whenever required.
- Respect privacy and confidentiality.
- Record observations accurately and systematically.
- Avoid influencing participants' behaviour.

Conclusion

The **observer–observed relationship** is an important aspect of research methodology. A balanced and ethical relationship between the researcher and participants ensures accurate, valid, and reliable data, thereby improving the overall quality of the research.

